THE TAMIL NADU COAST

A Hub of Water Sports

With a long and beautiful coastline, Tamil Nadu is a prime beach destination as well as a thriving setting for a variety of water sports









The state of Tamil Nadu has one of the most beautiful and extensive coastlines in India. The coast is rich in white sandy beaches as well as a unique history and tales of heritage. The numerous pristine beaches and lagoons lining the coast have rapidly become a hub for water sports enthusiasts as they offer a range of activities for tourists, including scuba diving, snorkelling, jet skiing, and parasailing.

The capital, Chennai, has many fine beaches. This includes the 13-km-long Marina Beach, which is the longest urban beach in India. Another prominent beach in Chennai is Elliot's Beach. Mamallapuram, or Mahabalipuram, which lies about 60 km south of Chennai, is a UNESCO World Heritage Site comprising around 40 ancient monuments and temples. These include Arjuna's Penance, one of the largest open-air rock reliefs in the world, monolithic chariot-shaped temples (Pancha Rathas), and the famous Shore Temple. The Shore Temple is also the magical setting for the Mamallapuram International Dance Festival.

One of the most popular destinations for water sports in Tamil Nadu is the Blue Flag Kovalam Beach. This beach is located near Chennai and is renowned for its clean waters and serene atmosphere. The Blue Flag certification is awarded to beaches that meet strict environmental and sustainability standards, making Kovalam Beach one of the most eco-friendly beaches in the country. The beach is perfect for swimming, sunbathing, and leisurely strolls, and offers visitors a wide range of water sports activities. Tourists can try their hand at kayaking, stand-up paddleboarding, windsurfing, and many other water sports.

There are several other interesting destinations along the Tamil Nadu coast. The coastal temple town of Chidambaram, 250 km from Chennai, is known for the Pichavaram Mangrove Forest. The ancient port city of Poompuhar, once called 'Kaveripoompattinam' or Puhar, has a gorgeous 3km long beach. The pearl-fishing centre of Thoothukudi has the Panimaya Matha Church built by the Portuguese in 1711 and the stunning-looking Manapad Beach. An important port in the Chola era, Nagapattinam has Chudamani Vihara, an important Buddhist structure, and a British-era lighthouse. Near Nagapattinam, the Basilica of Our Lady of Good Health in Velankanni is an important Catholic pilgrimage centre. The southernmost tip of the Indian mainland, Kanniyakumari is where the waters of the Bay of Bengal, the Arabian Sea and the Indian Ocean merge into one. The Vivekananda Rock Memorial and Thiruvalluvar Statue are the major attractions here.

Another water sports destination in Tamil Nadu is Rameswaram, offering activities like scuba diving and snorkelling in the Gulf of Mannar. Tourists can explore the underwater world and witness the stunning marine life, including colourful corals, sea turtles, and exotic fish. Rameswaram is also a popular destination for kite surfing enthusiasts. The windy conditions here make it an ideal location for this exhilarating sport. For those looking for a more leisurely water activity, Rameswaram also offers boat rides to explore the coastline and its many small islands. Tourists can also take a glass-bottom boat ride to witness the underwater world without getting wet.

Whether you're an experienced water sports enthusiasts or a first-timer, Tamil Nadu is the perfect destination for you.